

EG China, Taiwan: Beijing leveraging US truce to expand maritime control around Taiwan

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China, Taiwan

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Beijing leveraging US truce to expand maritime control around Taiwan

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- * Recent, unprecedented Chinese coast guard actions suggest Beijing sees its truce with Washington as an opportunity to expand its assertions of control over waters surrounding Taiwan.
 - * The risk of a soft quarantine, in which China requires ad hoc compliance from Taiwanese vessels, is rising but will not produce a crisis, because Washington is unlikely to meaningfully push back.
 - * Beijing is unlikely to adopt significantly more escalatory actions that could trigger a crisis (10% in 2026), such as temporarily blocking all commercial traffic into a Taiwanese port, or all energy shipments.

China likely seeking to normalize coast guard patrols near Taiwan's main island. The Chinese coast guard (CCG) conducted patrols in waters east of Taiwan on 1 June. This was followed by a special law enforcement operation on 6-8 June in waters southeast of Taiwan, during which CCG vessels entered Taiwan's 24-nautical-mile contiguous zone. A second CCG patrol east of Taiwan occurred on 4 July. These patrols were much closer to Taiwan than previous patrols, which were limited to Taiwan's offshore islands near the Chinese coast and in the South China Sea.

Beijing has also increased pressure around Taiwan-administered Pratas (Dongsha) and Itu Aba (Taiping Island) in the South China Sea, including deploying a coast guard vessel into Taiping Island's territorial waters for the first time on 11 June.

The patrols were nominally in response to Japan and the Philippines starting talks to delimit their exclusive economic zones that overlap in waters east of Taiwan. The more likely explanation is that Beijing seeks to consolidate its control of Taiwan and thinks the truce with the US affords a lower-cost environment to do so.

Patrols aim to exert administrative control over Taiwan's waters and erode sovereign claims. State media coverage of the patrols referred to waters east of Taiwan as China's "near sea" and implied that the CCG will build a constant presence there. On 27 June, a Chinese coast guard ship told a Taiwanese

coast guard vessel that the Republic of China (Taiwan's formal name) "does not exist."

The CCG will likely adopt its playbook of frequent patrols around Diaoyu (Senkaku) Islands to justify Beijing's territorial claims against Japan. In addition to CCG patrols, Chinese maritime research vessels will conduct routine surveys in waters near Taiwan to map out natural resources and critical seabed infrastructure, likely aimed at identifying pressure points for future coercion.

The risk of a soft quarantine is rising, but a crisis remains unlikely. During the 6-8 June special law enforcement operation, CCG vessels radioed three passing foreign-flagged commercial vessels for information for the first time. If China announces arbitrary customs rules without enforcement at sea or conducts ad hoc boarding inspections of Taiwanese vessels near Taiwan, that would amount to a soft quarantine. Such a scenario would be disruptive to maritime traffic in and out of the island but would ultimately not result in a crisis and have minimal market impact.

Cross-strait risks will remain low, as US unlikely to push back strongly on China's actions. In July, the US moved a squadron of coast guard cutters from the Middle East to the Western Pacific, in a likely effort to make up for the shortfall in military presence following prolonged deployments from Asia to the Middle East for the Iran war. However, US President Donald Trump is prioritizing maintaining the truce with Beijing over countering Chinese gray-zone military coercion against Taiwan. The Trump administration only conducted four US naval transits through the Taiwan Strait since 2025, while former president Joe Biden authorized nine transits in 2024 alone. Trump has continued to delay arms sales to Taiwan, which he views as leverage to obtain goodwill from China (see: Taiwan, China, United States: Trump will subordinate Taiwan arms sales to US-China stability , 19 May 2026). Eurasia Group contacts noted that Washington has shown disinterest in engaging Taipei on potential responses to quarantine scenarios.

In response to the new CCG patrols east of the island, only the de facto US embassy in Taipei issued a condemnation, not the State Department or the Pentagon.

Beijing is likely to avoid triggering a crisis (10% odds in 2026) to preserve the truce with Trump. China is unlikely to engage in more escalatory quarantines that carry a higher risk of a US response. Such actions include running a military exercise close to one of Taiwan's ports, effectively disrupting all traffic into and out of the island for the duration of the quarantine, or preventing all liquid natural gas carriers from reaching Taiwan. The risk of these forms of quarantines will gradually rise to 20% probability in 2028 (see Taiwan, China: Strait of Hormuz closure offers lessons for China's Taiwan playbook , 19 March 2026). Beijing is unlikely to take such escalatory actions absent unprecedented actions or statements by Washington or Taipei that support Taiwanese sovereignty.

A crisis scenario could also be triggered by a collision between Chinese and Taiwanese coast guard vessels or by Taiwan firing on a CCG vessel entering its 12-nautical-mile territorial waters. Neither scenario is likely, given Beijing's desire to avoid unnecessary escalation that could destabilize the US-China truce. Taipei, too, is acting with an abundance of caution, out of concern that a less sympathetic Trump administration will blame Taiwan for escalating if it were to respond too strongly to Chinese pressure.

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